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Territorial Disputes Involving Japan

Territorial disputes between Japan and its neighbors have escalated in recent months, prompting protests and diplomatic tensions. The disputes are linked to Japan's 20th-century military expansion across Asia, which ended in World War II, and persist until today. [Related Article »](#)

Senkaku Islands *(Japan's name)*
Diaoyu *(China's name)*

Kyodo News, via Associated Press

Claimed by China and Taiwan, but administered by Japan.

Dokdo *(South Korea)*
Takeshima Islands *(Japan)*

Lee Sang-hak/Yonhap, via Reuters

Administered by South Korea, but claimed by Japan.

Kurile Islands *(Russia)*
Northern Territories *(Japan)*

RIA Novosti, via Reuters

Controlled by Russia, claimed by Japan.

BACKGROUND

Japan annexed the islands in 1895, saying that they were unclaimed territory. It says China started showing interest in them only in the early 1970s, after possible oil reserves were discovered nearby. China says that the islands were Chinese for centuries and that Japan took them as a first step toward its later invasion of the Chinese mainland.

The barely inhabitable volcanic islets are surrounded by rich fishing grounds and natural gas deposits. Japan says it reconfirmed its right to Takeshima in 1905, during a war with Russia. Since the 1950s, South Korea has maintained a police post there.

Soviet forces occupied the islands in 1945, deported Japanese inhabitants and brought in settlers. In 1956, Russia offered to return one of the three islands claimed by Japan and a small group of islets as part of a peace treaty. But Japan rejected that compromise, maintaining that all the islands should be returned.

https://archive.nytimes.com/www.nytimes.com/interactive/2012/09/20/world/asia/Territorial-Disputes-Involving-Japan.html?_r=1&ref=asia

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LATEST DEVELOPMENTS	Anti-Japanese Protests In Dozens of Chinese Cities In July, Japan's prime minister Yoshihiko Noda announced his government's plans to buy three of the uninhabited islands, which are owned by a Japanese citizen. In September, Chinese patrol vessels sailed in the disputed waters around the islands. Anti-Japanese protests were held in dozens of Chinese cities in August and September.	South Korean President Visits the Islands President Lee Myung-bak of South Korea flew to the islands in August. Japan called Mr. Lee's visit "unacceptable" and recalled its ambassador from Seoul in protest. South Korea returned a letter Japan sent protesting the South Korean president's visit. Japan made the contents of the letter public.	Russia Sends Military Ships To the Islands In late August, Russia sent naval vessels near the islands to honor Soviet sailors who died at the end of World War II. In 2010, President Dmitri A. Medvedev, shown in the photo above, became the first Russian or Soviet leader to visit the disputed islands. He made it clear that Russia had no plans to cede the territory.
By THE NEW YORK TIMES			
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